

Honors and Non-Honors Students: A Comparative Study on Academic, Dispositional and Emotional Factors

Sylvia Tsai, Annabel Kim, Isabella Lu, Nicholas Nguyen, Aditi Salunkhe,
and Shireen Mohamdjawad
Irvine Valley College

Suggested Bibliographic Reference

Tsai, S., Kim, A., Lu, I., Nguyen, N., Salunkhe, A., & Mohamdjawad, S. (2024). Honors and non-honors students: A comparative study on academic, dispositional and emotional factors. *Psi Beta Research Journal*, 4(1), 1-8.
<https://doi.org/10.54581/PETD7159>

Abstract

In the realm of higher education, the question persists: Does the distinction of being an honors student inherently pave the way for academic excellence? The present study aims to examine differences between honors and non-honors students across multiple factors that may relate to success in college. Participants were students from community colleges throughout the United States as part of a national Psi Beta project. Data from this study were collected via an online survey through SONA Systems to maintain participants' anonymity. A total of 2,074 participants read and signed an informed consent page, and then completed eight self-report measures (honors society engagement, school engagement, belongingness, academic self-efficacy, sense of purpose and meaning, grit, happiness, and loneliness). Results showed that honors society students (compared to non-honors students) had more school engagement, purpose and meaning, grit, and academic self-efficacy. In logistic stepwise regression, academic self-efficacy was the strongest predictor of honors society membership, and school engagement was the best predictor of honors program membership. Also, students in both honors societies and honors programs were more likely to obtain a mentor and report greater engagement in high school.

Keywords: honors society, honors program, mentorship, community college, school engagement, belongingness, self-esteem, academic self-efficacy, purpose, meaning, grit, happiness, loneliness

Honors and non-honors students demonstrate clear differences in terms of school engagement and academic performance. Honors students exhibit behaviors that are positively correlated with academic performance (Buckner et al., 2023; Scager et al., 2012)—namely, honors students exhibit higher GPAs compared to non-honors students and are more involved in extracurricular activities (Abizada & Mirzaliyeva, 2021; Kool et al., 2016). Additionally, honors students maintain

attendance (skipping class less often), prepare longer for classes, ask more questions during lectures, spend more time rewriting papers, and meet with faculty more frequently outside class hours compared to non-honors students (Fuiks & Clark, 2002; Harte, 1994; Long & Lange, 2002; Schuman, 2006). It is particularly noteworthy that honors students seem to limit distractions to their successful academic performances (e.g., watching television and drinking alcohol), which allows

Correspondence concerning this article should be addressed to Sylvia Tsai, Irvine Valley College, 5500 Irvine Center Drive, CA 92618, United States. Email: stsai22@ivc.edu

This study was conducted as part of the Psi Beta National Research Project. The authors would like to thank Dr. Kari Tucker for her guidance in this research, and to Dr. Jerry Rudmann who dedicated his life and career to improving students' learning, college experiences, and academic success.

them to focus more on their grades and overall academic success (Fuiks & Clark, 2002; Harte, 1994; Long & Lange, 2002; Schuman, 2006). Furthermore, honors students exhibit a greater desire to learn new material and demonstrate higher levels of creativity (Buckner et al., 2023; Scager et al., 2012). These findings suggest that honors students seem to possess personal characteristics and make positive choices that lead to better academic outcomes and may pave the way for even greater success in their futures.

Honors societies often provide academic enrichment opportunities, such as seminars, workshops, and guest lectures, which can enhance students' learning experiences beyond the classroom. Participation in honors societies facilitates networking with like-minded peers and faculty members. These connections can lead to mentorship, collaboration on projects, and potential career opportunities. Honors societies have numerous benefits that include not only a level of prestige, but opportunities for continuing education, and networking for professional career advancement (Hopkins et al., 2016). Honors society engagement is a contributing factor to academic success as it provides enrichment opportunities and learning experiences that non-honors students may otherwise not be able to access.

Other factors have been identified as strong contributors to academic success. For example, school engagement (e.g., doing homework, working on one's skills and abilities in school subjects, and having school social relationships) is positively related to academic success (Goodenow, 1993). School engagement is particularly important because students who have greater engagement report a greater sense of belongingness on the college campus than students who report lower engagement (for a review, see Goodenow, 1993). When a student feels like they belong in a school setting, there can be numerous benefits that come along with it, such as feeling

like they are respected, accepted, and supported (Goodenow, 1993).

In addition to school engagement, academic self-efficacy is also related to a student's success in college. Academic self-efficacy (ASE) involves a personal evaluation of one's skills, including confidence in learning ability and learning behavior, which plays an important role in educational achievement (Chen et al., 2024). Students with higher ASE set challenging goals and persist through difficulties, and well as report greater confidence in completing tasks, and more active participation (Buckner et al., 2023; Chen et al., 2024; Scager et al., 2012). It could be that with this greater confidence, students with high ASE are more ready to take on even greater challenges that reinforce their academic prowess.

Another factor that is related to greater academic success is one's personal disposition of "grit." Grit is defined as perseverance and passion for long-term goals and is a significant predictor of academic success and personal achievement (Duckworth & Quinn, 2009). This quality enables students to remain steady in their pursuits, maintaining focus and effort over extended periods. Research shows that grit (i.e., perseverance in goal social setting) is directly related to enhanced students' efficiency, autonomy, and performance (Moeller et al., 2012).

While not linked directly to academic behaviors or performances, a sense of purpose and meaning in life may have an indirect role in students' academic success. A sense of purpose includes being goal-directed, having personal meaning, and a beyond-the-self orientation. Both purpose and meaning are viewed as a developmental asset, a key aspect of thriving, and a central component of psychological well-being, and seem to be typically demonstrated in their dedication of time, energy, and resources to its pursuit (Bronk et al., 2018). For students, this could create a long-term perspective that goes beyond immediate academic pressures and tasks (Bronk et al., 2018) and help them carry on even in the face

of challenges or defeat, motivating them even more after successes.

It is reasonable to imagine that with greater success in general and academic success in particular (i.e., greater engagement, academic outcomes, extracurricular activities, desires/motivation to learn, academic focus, etc.), the greater happiness students should have about themselves and their lives. This is supported by the finding that happier students report that the better their grades are, the more they feel as if they are heading in the right direction with their careers (Lyubomirsky & Lepper, 1999). Also, students who obtain better grades in college also report less loneliness. This is bolstered by the fact that students' loneliness has an inverse relationship with both various cognitive abilities and academic achievement overall (Atkinson, 2023). These results highlight the importance of academic success, suggesting that improving academic success may have importance outside of the classroom as well, perhaps contributing to better emotional experiences and life satisfaction.

The purpose of the present study was to compare honors students with non-honors students with several factors previously related to academic success. An additional aim was to identify the strongest predictors of honors society and honors program membership. Several hypotheses are posed: (1) Honors society students, compared to non-honors society students, will have greater levels of School Engagement, ASE, sense of purpose and meaning, grit and happiness but less loneliness; (2) ASE and grit will serve as the strongest predictors for honors society membership because students in honors society are more likely to set higher academic goals and work diligently to achieve them, having a sustained effort and passion for long-term goals, aligning with honors society ambitions; (3) School Engagement and ASE will serve as the strongest predictors for honors program membership because students who are highly engaged in school are more likely to participate within honors programs; (4) Students in

honors societies will have a higher likelihood of having mentors compared to those not in honors societies; (5) Students in honors programs will be more likely to have mentors compared to those not in honors programs; (6) The strongest predictors of students having mentors will be ASE, grit, and a greater sense of purpose and meaning because students with high ASE are confident in their academic abilities and may seek mentors to further develop their skills and knowledge. In addition, those with high levels of grit are more willing to commit to continuous improvement, and mentors can offer the necessary guidance and encouragement. Individuals with a strong sense of purpose and meaning are driven to achieve their goals and may seek mentors who can help them succeed.

Method

Participants

Participants included 2,074 students from various community colleges across the United States as a part of the national Psi Beta project. The gender distribution comprised 1,452 females, 535 males, 52 nonbinary participants, with the remaining 35 participants either identifying as other or preferring not to disclose this information. The age ranged from 18 to 82 years.

Measures

Honors society engagement was measured using an 8-item scale. Participants used a 5-point scale (1 = *not applicable*, 5 = *always*). School Engagement was measured by the 18-item Psychological Sense of School Membership Scale (Goodenow, 1993). Participants used a 5-point scale (1 = *not*, 5 = *completely true*). Items 3, 6, 9, 12, and 16 were reverse coded. Belongingness was measured by The Need to Belong Scale (Leary et al., 2013), which is a 10-item scale. Participants used a 5-point scale (1 = *strongly disagree*, 5 = *strongly agree*). Items 32, 34, and 38 were reverse coded. Academic self-efficacy (ASE) was measured by the 11-item Self-Efficacy for Self-Regulated Learning scale (Zimmerman et al., 1992). Participants used a 7-point scale (1 = *not*, 7

Table 1*Coefficients and Significance for All Predictors of Honors Society Membership*

Predictor	<i>B</i>	<i>SE B</i>	β	<i>t</i>	<i>P</i>
Constant	-.384	.080		-4.772	.000
Academic self-efficacy	.023	.008	.084	2.859	.004**
Belongingness	.023	.010	.055	2.244	.025*
School engagement	.048	.013	.103	3.626	.000***
Loneliness	.036	.015	.077	2.388	.017*
Purpose and meaning	.037	.013	.087	2.772	.006**
Subjective happiness	-.018	.007	-.074	-2.387	.017*

Note. Stepwise logistic regression looking at the predictors of honors society membership. The strongest predictor was academic self-efficacy.

^a Honors society membership (*yes* vs. *no*) was the dependent variable for this logistic regression.

* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

= *well*). Sense of purpose and meaning were measured by the Claremont Purpose Scale (Bronk et al., 2018), which was a 12-item scale. Participants made their rating using a 5-point scale (1 = *not*, 5 = *extremely clear*). Grit was measured by the Short Grit Scale (Duckworth & Quinn, 2009), which was a 12-item scale. Participants used a 5-point scale (1 = *not*, 5 = *very much like me*). Sub-items that measured consistency of interest were reverse-coded. Subjective happiness was measured using The Subjective Happiness Scale (Lyubomirsky & Lepper, 1999), which was a 4-item scale. Participants used a 7-point scale (1 = *not a very happy person*, 7 = *a very happy person*). Item 4 was reverse-coded. Loneliness was measured by the UCLA Loneliness Scale (Hays & DiMatteo, 1987), which was an 8-item scale. Participants used a 4-point scale (1 = *never*, 4 = *often*).

Procedure

Participants were recruited nationally from various participating community colleges with active Psi Beta chapters. Participants accessed and completed an online survey through Sona Systems,

an online tool that allows participants to access participation while maintaining anonymity. All participants read and signed consent forms, which included information about participants' right to withdraw at any time without penalty, their right to privacy and confidentiality, the purpose of the study, contact information in case they had further questions, and potential risks and benefits of participating. Next, participants completed the online survey, which took approximately 30 minutes to complete. Lastly, all participants were debriefed and thanked for their time.

Results

The first set of hypotheses was mostly supported. Honors society students compared to non-honors society students had significantly higher levels of School Engagement, $t(1991) = 4.98, p < .001$, ASE, $t(2035) = 5.53, p < .001$, purpose and meaning, $t(2032) = 4.75, p < .001$, and grit, $t(2036) = 3.13, p = .002$. However, there were no differences between honors society students compared to non-honors society students on happiness, $t(2032) = -0.51, p = 0.61$, or loneliness, $t(2032) = 0.96, p = 0.34$.

Table 2*Coefficients and Significance for All Predictors of Honors Program Membership*

Predictor	<i>B</i>	<i>SE B</i>	β	<i>t</i>	<i>P</i>
Constant	-.296	.073		-4.053	.000
School engagement	.062	.015	.121	4.223	.000***
Academic self-efficacy	.024	.008	.081	3.024	.003**
Loneliness	.040	.014	.077	2.854	.004**

Note. Stepwise logistic regression looking at the predictors of honors program membership. The strongest predictor was school engagement.

^a Honors program membership (*yes* vs. *no*) was the dependent variable for this logistic regression.

* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

The second set of hypotheses was partially supported. ASE was the strongest predictor for honors society membership, $\beta = .08$, $p = .004$, however, grit did not predict additional variance in the final model. See Table 1 for all variables included in the model.

The third hypothesis was supported. School Engagement was the strongest predictor for honors program membership, $\beta = .12$, $p < .001$, and ASE was the second strongest predictor for honors program membership, $\beta = .08$, $p = .003$. See Table 2 for all variables included in the model.

The fourth hypothesis was supported. Students in honors societies had a higher chance of having mentors compared to those not in honors societies, $\chi^2(1) = 56.62$, $p < .001$; $\phi = .19$.

The fifth hypothesis was supported. Students in honors programs had a higher chance of having mentors compared to those not in honors programs, $\chi^2(1) = 67.71$, $p < .001$; $\phi = .21$.

receiving mentorship; possibly since honors students spend more time meeting with faculty outside class hours (Fiuk & Clark, 2002; Harte, 1994; Long & Lange, 2002; Schuman, 2006).

While several hypotheses were supported, the second and sixth hypotheses were only partially supported as ASE and School Engagement were

The sixth set of hypotheses was partially supported. School Engagement was the strongest predictor of having a mentor, $\beta = .27$, $p < .001$. Purpose and meaning were the second strongest predictors of having a mentor, $\beta = .10$, $p = .001$. ASE, grit, and a greater sense of purpose and meaning did not predict additional variance in the model. See Table 3 for all variables included in the model.

Discussion

Results showed that honors society and program students had significantly higher levels of School Engagement, ASE, purpose and meaning, and grit (although not more happy or less lonely), which is consistent with the current literature. ASE and School Engagement were the strongest predictors of honors society membership and honors program membership, respectively. There was a positive association between students with honors society and program membership and the strongest predictors of honors society membership, respectively. These results are important because honors students possess several characteristics and traits that may lend themselves to even greater success in their futures compared to non-honors students—greater School Engagement, ASE, purpose and meaning and grit. Interestingly,

Table 3*Coefficients and Significance Levels for All Predictors of Mentorship Status*

Predictor	<i>B</i>	<i>SE B</i>	β	<i>t</i>	<i>P</i>
Model 1					
Constant	-.416	.067		-6.245	.000
School engagement	.227	.018	.314	12.739	.000***
Model 2					
Constant	-.549	.077		-7.156	.000
School engagement	.036	.015	.077	2.388	.000***
Purpose and meaning	-.018	.007	-.074	-2.387	.000***

Note. Stepwise logistic regression looking at the predictors of having a mentor. The strongest predictor was school engagement, followed by purpose and meaning.

^a Mentorship status (having one or not) was the dependent variable for this test.

* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

honors students were not different in their levels of happiness and loneliness, which seems to imply these states may be independent of being an honors student or not. When examining factors that predict honors society membership, ASE but not grit, was the strongest predictor. Grit may be important, but perhaps not in addition to efficacious behavior that has already been established. It is interesting to note that honors society membership and honors program membership had different factors as their strongest predictors. While ASE was one of the top two predictors for both (being the strongest for honors society membership), School Engagement was the strongest predictor of honors program membership. It could be that confidence in oneself may be more important when reaching out to learn about the requirements of a program that represents the college as a whole (i.e., honors programs), as opposed to the more situational opportunities that are often presented in classrooms by department members/faculty (i.e., honors societies). Lastly, the results suggested the importance of having a mentor—that is, having a mentor was related to

both honors society and honors program membership. Along these lines, School Engagement also showed itself to be the strongest predictor of having a mentor.

Seeking a mentor, asking for help, taking advice, and taking advantage of opportunities (in college, or even learning about honors societies and programs) may simply require confidence in oneself to seek them out. Perhaps these “confident” behaviors could be learned, practiced, or developed. Practicing these behaviors could lead to greater confidence in oneself and their abilities. It may prove beneficial for educational institutions to develop mentorship programs geared towards all students to help them develop skills and provide similar opportunities without restrictive barriers of entry that societies and programs may have.

There are two notable limitations to this study. Socio-economic status (SES) of students was not considered. While the survey asked about employment and hours worked, it did not ask students to specify their perceived socio-economic status. It could be that students in lower SES

groups may not have similar opportunities to seek a mentor or spend additional time on campus pursuing additional opportunities. Future research should examine the role of SES as a moderating factor in these findings. Additionally, only students residing in the U.S. were sampled and did not distinguish international and U.S. students. Differing cultural and social factors may play a role in whether students seek membership in prestigious programs or seek a mentor. To some, membership in these programs could be a goal itself (e.g., seeking to bring prestige to one's family), while for others, membership could highlight future opportunities. Future research should examine whether it is membership or the information and/or opportunities that come from these societies and programs that make the difference in student success factors.

Overall, this study provides more insight into certain variables that may play a factor in honors society and program membership, which supports the current literature (e.g., Buckner et al., 2023; Fuiks & Clark, 2002; Harte, 1994; Long & Lange, 2002; Scager et al., 2012; Schuman, 2006). Honors societies and programs are important to college campuses—membership in these are related not only to academic success, but also to other dispositional qualities of the students (School Engagement, ASE, purpose and meaning, and grit), and other opportunities that could be extremely useful (e.g., information that is presented outside of the classroom experience that could potentially lead to other successes in students' futures such as those provided by a personal mentor). The causal direction between honors societies/program membership and qualities of students (ASE, School Engagement, purpose and meaning, and grit) are unknown, so educational institutions would benefit by providing resources to develop both by providing pathways and opportunities for students to learn and qualify for membership in honors societies and programs (and thus benefit from the collaboration and elements of those societies and programs), as well as providing

services for all students to develop skills/knowledge that leads to the expression of academically efficacious and confident behaviors that could lead to other life-changing opportunities. Above all, what seemed to be suggested by the results was that mentorship seems to be important for college success and thus educational institutions should provide greater mentorship opportunities for all students, from the beginning of their academic career, not only those who have the personal confidence to pursue it.

References

- Abizada, A. & Mirzaliyeva, F. (2021). Success of honors program in Azerbaijan: Do honors students perform better than non-honors students. *Journal of Advanced Academics*, 32(2), 160-177. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1932202X20973999>
- Atkinson, S. (2023, April 13). *Loneliness affects each student differently*. Nursing Times. <https://www.nursingtimes.net/students/loneliness-affects-each-student-differently-13-04-2023/>
- Bronk, K. C., Riches, B. R., & Mangan, S. A. (2018). Claremont purpose scale: A measure that assesses the three dimensions of purpose among adolescents. *Research in Human Development*, 15(2), 101-117. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15427609.2018.1441577>
- Buckner, E., Shores, M., Sloane, M., Shields, C., Danzler, J., Shader, K., & Newcomer, B. (2023). Honors and non-honors student engagement: A model of student, curricular, and institutional characteristics. *Department of Education*, 119–217. <https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/EJ1104310.pdf>
- Chen, Q., Zhang, Q., Yu, F., & Hou, B. (2024). Investigating structural relationships between professional identity, learning engagement, academic self-efficacy, and university support: Evidence from tourism students in China. *Behavioral Sciences*, 14(1), 26. <https://www.mdpi.com/2076-328X/14/1/26>
- Duckworth, A. L., & Quinn, P. D. (2009). Development and validation of the Short Grit Scale (Grit-S). *Journal of Personality Assessment*, 91(2), 166-174. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00223890802634290>
- Fuiks, L. C. & Clark, L. (2002). *Teaching and learning in honors*. (2nd ed.). National Collegiate Honors Council. <https://digitalcommons.unl.edu/nchcmmono/9/>

- [?utm_source=digitalcommons.unl.edu%2Fnhcmono-%2F9&utm_medium=PDF&utm_campaign=PDFCoverPages](#)
- Goodenow, C. (1993). The psychological sense of school membership among adolescents: Scale development and educational correlates (3rd ed.). *Psychology in the Schools*, 30(1), 79-90. [https://psycnet.apa.org/doi/10.1002/15206807\(199301\)30:1%3C79::AID-PITS2310300113%3E3.0.CO;2-X](https://psycnet.apa.org/doi/10.1002/15206807(199301)30:1%3C79::AID-PITS2310300113%3E3.0.CO;2-X)
- Harte, T. B. (1994). Honors and non-honors students: How different are they? *The National Honors Report*, 15(1), 12-14.
- Hays, R. D., & DiMatteo, R. M., (1987). A short-form measure of loneliness. *Journal of Personality Assessment*, 51(1), 69-81. https://doi.org/10.1207/s15327752jpa5101_6
- Hopkins, E. E., Robb, M., Fisher, M., Slade, J. D., Wasco, J. J., Spadaro, K. C., & Doas, M. (2016). Honor society membership retention strategies: Promoting membership benefits from induction through transition to professional practice. *Journal of Nursing Education and Practice*, 6(12), 18-23. <https://doi.org/10.5430/jnep.v6n12p18>
- Kool, A., Mainhard, M. T., Jaarsma, A. D. C., Brekelmans, M., & van Beukelen, P. (2016). Academic success and early career outcomes: Can honors alumni be distinguished from non-honors alumni? *High Ability Studies*, 27(2), 179–192. <https://psycnet.apa.org/doi/10.1080/13598139.2016.1238818>
- Leary, M. R., Kelly, K. M., Cottrell, C. A., & Schreindorfer, L. S. (2013). Construct validity of the Need to Belong Scale: Mapping the nomological network. *Journal of Personality Assessment*, 95(6), 610-624. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00223891.2013.819511>
- Long, E. C. J. & Lange, S. (2002). An exploratory study: A comparison of honors & non-honors students. *The National Honors Report*, 23(1), 20-30. <https://digitalcommons.unl.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1005&context=nchenhr>
- Lyubomirsky, S. & Lepper, S. H. (1999). A measure of subjective happiness: Preliminary reliability and construct validation. *Social Indicators Research* 46(2), 137-155. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/27522363>
- Moeller, A. K., Theiler, J. M., & Wu, C. (2012). Goal setting and student achievement: A longitudinal study. *The Modern Language Journal* 96(2), 153-169. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1540-4781.2011.01231.x>
- Scager, K., Akkerman, S. F., Keesen, F., Mainhard, T. M., Pilot, A., & Wubbels, T. (2012). Do honors students have more potential for excellence in their professional lives? *High Education*, 64, 19–39. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10734-011-9478-z>
- Schuman, S. (2006). *Beginning in honors: A handbook*. (4th ed.). National Collegiate Honors Council. <https://digitalcommons.unl.edu/nchemono/7/>
- Zimmerman, B. J., Bandura, A., & Martinez-Pons, M. (1992). Self-motivation for academic attainment: The role of self-efficacy beliefs and personal goal setting (4th ed.). *American Educational Research Journal*, 29(3), 663-676. <https://doi.org/10.3102/00028312029003663>